

The Ugly Alleyway

"Oh what's over there?" pointed Fiona. The alleyway looked beautiful in the lazy afternoon sunlight. A huge lawn hedge faced a brick wall of street art. It seemed exotic compared to the suburbia they had been walking through.

"We can't go that way," Liam steered her clear. Something fluttered in her chest when he grabbed her wrist. She had been waiting for him to touch her.

"Are you sure?" Fiona replied with a smile.

"Yes." His grip tightened, until she wrested out of his control, taking a step back.

"Why are you hurting me?"

"Just leave it ok?"

"Look, I know we don't truly know each other yet, but I don't want to be controlled. And I want to be able to say how I feel. I think it's a good idea to go down there."

Before he could answer she closed the gap between them, her voice softening.

"And you should come with me."

Wait. Was that a tear rolling down his cheek?

"Please, don't go down there. Please."

"It's alright, what happened there, why don't you tell me?"

"I can't. You won't believe me unless you go yourself. It's ... *evil*." Liam seemed to be staring far away into the distance.

Fiona felt fear. But only for a second when realisation hit her.

"You're gaslighting me aren't you? Jesus, over the direction of where we walk on our second date? You want to control me that bad do you?"

"No Fiona, I ..."

"Well you're not the first man do that to me and you certainly won't be the last. But I'm not letting myself be manipulated again. And to think I thought you were..." She shook her head.

"Goodbye Liam."

Fiona walked to the alleyway.

"Please Fiona, I didn't mean...!"

"Save it! I don't want to hear it."

Liam sobbed in his hands. Fiona scoffed as she reached the front of the alleyway. The green hedge was even larger up close, expanding over the side of a long shoulder height wooden fence, while opposite was a long brick wall,

proliferated with street art, colours and creations lining every surface. The closest painting to her was a red man holding a trident, his chiselled chest connected to furry legs that ended in hooves.

Fiona prepared to enter, one foot in the air when she heard Liam's voice.

"Do me a favour then. And run."

She sighed and advanced.

The sunlight disappeared.

She looked back with surprise, her vision of Liam and the street was blocked by a deep black darkness. The way forward was only just visible, red and blue light from the street art slicing through the shadows. Fiona looked with shock at the piece she had noticed. The red man had begun *moving*.

Horns grew out of his head, and he began peeling himself off of the wall.

What was this?

Fiona felt fear when the man looked at her, his gaze was predatory.

The trident stabbed at her. Managing to avoid its sharp points, Fiona began running, laughter echoing with her every step. With horror, Fiona saw other monsters begin coming to

life on the brick wall, and instinctively she backed to the other side, to the Hedge.

Something soft and wrinkly touched her underarm.

Fiona looked down and screamed.

A black, withered arm was stroking her arm. When she tried to pull away it grabbed her, dead fingers tightening. More arms shot out of the Hedge, grabbing her arms, her legs, her mouth.

Fingers spread over her eyes, rolled down her cheeks, stuck themselves in her nostrils. Fiona's kept screaming, an endless shriek, as she felt herself be dragged backwards, until the green shrubs covered her vision, dirt and skin sliding down her throat to drown her in a muddy, squelchy hell.